



△ **Round, mixed-cut** pollucite gem

Pollucite

Discovered in 1846, pollucite is one of two minerals named after Castor and Pollux, the Gemini twins in Greek mythology (see box, below), although the other, castorite, has since been renamed petalite (see p.196). Pollucite is found only in rare element-bearing deposits, where it occurs with other gem minerals such as spodumene, petalite, quartz, and apatite. Facet-grade material tends to be very small, but crystals up to 60cm (24in) across have been found at Kamdeysh in Afghanistan. It also occurs in Italy and the USA.

Specification

Chemical name Cesium sodium aluminosilicate

Formula $(\text{Cs,Na})(\text{AlSi}_2)_6\text{O}_6\text{H}_2\text{O}$ | **Colours** Colourless, white, pink, blue, violet

| **Structure** Cubic | **Hardness** 6.5–7

SG 2.85–2.94 | **RI** 1.51–1.525 | **Lustre** Vitreous to greasy

Streak White | **Locations** Afghanistan, Elba, Italy, USA



Pollucite rough | **Rough** | Only an expert cutter will be able to see through the rough, water-worn exterior to glimpse the fine, gem-quality material inside.



Massive pollucite | **Rough** | This piece of massive pollucite was found in Buckfield, Maine, in the USA. This is a broken fragment; well-formed crystals are rare and are especially prized in the jewellery trade.



Mixed cut | **Cut** | This pendeloque pollucite gemstone features triangular facets on the crown and rectangular, step-cut facets on the pavilion.



Octagonal step cut | **Cut** | The rectangular, cushion step cut, faceted to reveal the gem's vitreous lustre, emphasizes the pale blue of this pollucite.



Unusual cut | **Cut** | The cutter of this 2.69-carat, oval pollucite has faceted the gem in an unusual way, accentuating its radiance and exquisite peach hue.

Castor and Pollux

Mythological warriors

In Greek and Roman mythology, Castor and Pollux were twin brothers renowned for their horsemanship. The Romans believed that their victory at the Battle of Lake Regillus was aided by the mythological twins, and built the Temple of Castor and Pollux in Rome's Forum to honour them. Each year on 15 July, the 1,800 members of Rome's elite cavalry paraded through the city to commemorate the military victory.



Castor and Pollux The brothers are portrayed in these Roman statuettes from the 3rd century CE.